DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

God Is One: What Does It Really Mean?

Daat Tevunot §34-36

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §34-36 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 3 October 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Verse upon verse (§34, continued)

Last time the Sekhel established that the only thing we can fully understand about God is His unity, because it is a negation; His other perfections are beyond our grasp. The Ramhal now brings verse after verse from the prophets to show that revealing this unity is the purpose of everything: - Yeshayahu: so that you know that I am He; before Me no god was formed and after Me there will be none. "I am Hashem and there is no other." From the rising of the sun to its setting there is nothing besides Me. I form light and create darkness, make peace and create evil: it is all one. - The verses keep saying "you shall know" and "you shall understand," knowing with understanding. - The line to underline: the goal of everything the prophets promised is the revelation of His unity to all. Hence the verse about the nations all coming to call on the name of Hashem and serve Him together, and what we say every day, "Shema Yisrael, Hashem Elokenu, Hashem Ehad."

The sum of it: all we can fully grasp of God's perfection is His unity, and when we look at everything that has happened under heaven, we see one cycle whose end purpose is to reveal it. (The Rabbi noted that part of this paragraph is missing from the English edition.)

Knowing it in the heart (§34-35)

That is why the verse says "vahashevota el levavekha": it takes concentration and focus to bring this down from theory into the heart, to feel it and live it. "I have already told you this is a great and wide sea," says the Sekhel, and we will swim in it as far as we need. The Neshamah asks: what do I need to understand here? Surely "one" is simple: God is one.

Yihud Hashem and Yom Kippur

With Yom Kippur two days away, the Rabbi applied this directly. The end of Yom Kippur repeats "Hashem hu haElokim." The four-letter name is rahamim, when we see God; Elokim is din, when we do not see Him. The verse declares that they are the same. There are not good days when God is with me and bad days when He has abandoned me. After forty days of Selihot, tefillah and teshuvah, the climax is to change our perspective to yihud Hashem. When a person truly lives with it, teshuvah becomes easy.

- **Anger:** if we truly believed there is no other force besides Hashem, what would there be to get angry about? The Gemara compares one who gets angry to one who serves idols, because anger implies duality.
- **A bad deal:** if you did all your checks and still lost money, that is in Hashem's hand. A participant pressed the point and the Rabbi agreed: if you were negligent, you cannot absolve yourself by pointing to Hashem. You must look in the mirror and learn from the mistake, or you will repeat it.
- **Lashon hara and every temptation:** all the things we think will do us good and all the bad are from Hashem, put there so that we turn away from them and turn to Him. Every desire is a test of recognising yihud Hashem.

The model is Gan Eden. The issue was not merely eating or not eating from a tree. The serpent said "vihyitem keElokim," you will be like God, with your own power. Every indulgence says: I have my own autonomy, my own body, I can enjoy myself. That is a denial of yihud Hashem. The verse lists the pull: the tree was good to eat (taste), a delight to the eyes (sight), and desirable to make one wise (curiosity). All desire comes through the senses, and every sense is a test. We understand this intellectually; living it is "the test of a lifetime."

A question on free will

A participant suggested that if a person chooses to harm another, his ability to act is still under yihud Hashem, so in reality there is no autonomy. "Everything until that last sentence was correct," said the Rabbi, adding that asking it showed he had understood everything. If you negate autonomy, you make a mockery of free will: why punish a murderer who had no choice? So: - A human being has free will and can act even against God's will. If someone was sealed for life on Yom Kippur, another person could still decide to kill him two days later; to say otherwise limits free will. - Yihud Hashem relates to everything in the world except human free will. It must be so, or life becomes meaningless. - Within that, Hashem can still arrange things: a person may be sent away on a trip so he is not at home to be burgled, and in rare cases, for the righteous, there is direct intervention. But that is not the default. - Our own choice to do wrong is itself a failure to see yihud Hashem: the temptation was a setup for us to turn away from, like the tree in Gan Eden.

Asked whether yihud Hashem means annulling oneself, the Rabbi said: not annulling yourself, but annulling everything around you. "It's easy for me to talk about this. It's another thing to live with it. We all struggle with it."

The full meaning of oneness (§36)

The Sekhel now explains. The general idea is that God is one, but we have to internalise "ein od milvado," there is nothing besides Him: no witchcraft, no magical powers, no other forces. The Rabbi called these the key lines: - It is not enough to say there is one God, one deity and no other creative power. That is what we were taught as children, the simple level. - We must understand that there is no other ruler or authority apart from Him, no director of the world or of any creature in it besides Him, and nothing that can prevent His will.

That is the complete oneness of His rule. As the verse in Haazinu says, "I put to death and I give life": the good and the bad all come from Me; there are no other forces in control. And Iyov

says: He is one, and who can turn Him back?

Coming next

Next the Ramhal will go through five common mistakes by which people, even religious people, deny yihud Hashem. The shiurim break for Sukkot and resume afterwards, and the Rabbi asked the group to use the time to review: "This is what your whole Yom Kippur is about."

Summary

- The prophets repeat that the purpose of all history and all their promises is the revelation of God's unity to all.
- Knowing it is not enough; it must be brought into the heart, "vahashevota el levavekha."
- "Hashem hu haElokim" at the end of Yom Kippur says that rahamim and din, good days and bad, are one; living this makes anger and sin fall away.
- Human free will is real and is the one area yihud Hashem leaves open; every temptation is a test of seeing God's unity.
- True oneness means no other ruler, director or force at all: "ein od milvado."

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